SOPHANDROS

The Parent's Guide

Using Sophandros with an advanced student at home

How to choose an edition, plan the weeks, adapt the exercises, check the writing, and record the course on a transcript.

Who it is for

Sophandros was written for adults: professionals who want the foundation a classical education once gave. It suits a strong student of about fifteen and older who reads well above grade level and can write a page of connected argument. A younger student who reads widely may manage it with a parent alongside.

The quickest test is Chapter 1, which is free to read at sophandros.com. If your student can read it in one or two sittings, follow the passages from the *Iliad*, and talk about what Achilles should have done, the course is within reach.

> **What the readings contain.** The readings are the classical texts themselves, in public-domain translations, and they describe war, slavery, death and the abuse of power as their authors did. The chapters discuss these matters plainly and in proportion. You may want to read each week's selection before your student does, at least for the first few weeks, so that you are ready to talk about it.

The book is built on one idea. As civilization grew, so did a man's circle of influence, and he had to learn to govern larger and larger bodies: first himself, then his household, his city, a republic, an empire, the wider world and finally a new nation. Each larger circle demanded skills the smaller one never taught. The course grows the same way: each chapter widens the circle by one step and adds the skill that step required. The lessons it draws apply to any reader.

Its aim is what the Greeks called *phronēsis*, practical wisdom: the judgment to see what ought to be done in the case in front of you. Aristotle thought it grows from experience of particular cases, and the classics are the largest store of such cases we have. For a young student, the course supplies the cases early; the exercises and your conversations each week are where they start to become judgment.

Choosing an edition

- **The core course (12 weeks).** 21 of the 26 chapters, usually two a week. A good fit for a single semester alongside other subjects, or as a summer course.
- **The extended edition (26 weeks).** All 26 chapters, one a week. A full school year at a steady pace, or one semester for a student who works on it daily.
- **The book.** The same 26 chapters as a PDF, without the weekly self-checks. Useful as a second copy for a parent who wants to read along.

A student who begins with the core course can move up to the extended edition later. If you are teaching more than one child, a family license covers every student in one household: the core course for $175, the extended edition for $325.

A week of study

Each chapter follows the same shape, so a week settles into a routine. The course plans on about three and a half hours a week, in these pieces:

- **Two lessons** (2 × 30 min). The teacher's essay: the setting, the passage, what it means, and someone who used it.
- **The reading** (60–75 min). The week's selection on the page, in a public-domain translation.
- **Latin phrases** (15 min). Three to five phrases still used in law, medicine, business or daily life.
- **The exercise** (20 min). One of the classical writing drills, applied to your own work.
- **Commonplace book** (10 min). Copy one passage by hand and write two sentences on what it means for you.
- **Check yourself** (5 min). Five questions on the week's reading, with answers to reveal when you are done. Course only.

A sample week

Day	Work
Monday	First lesson. Read "What you will learn" and the introduction.
Tuesday	The reading, first half. Mark one passage worth copying.
Wednesday	The reading, second half. Second lesson. The Latin phrases.
Thursday	The exercise: a first draft.
Friday	Revise the exercise, write the commonplace-book entry, take the self-check, then talk it over with a parent.

The Friday conversation matters more than any other piece. The old schools taught by talk as much as by books, and a student who can explain a chapter aloud has learned it.

Pacing

The core course

Week	Chapters
1	P1 Before the Greeks; P2 The first Greeks
2	Ch. 1 The self; Ch. 2 The household
3	Ch. 3 The city at war
4	Ch. 5 The city questioned; Ch. 6 The ideal city
5	Ch. 7 The citizen's judgment; Ch. 8 The whole city
6	Ch. 10 The republic
7	Ch. 11 The forum
8	Ch. 12 The statesman; Ch. 13 The ruler under empire
9	Ch. 15 Christendom; Ch. 18 The nation-state
10	Ch. 19 The Founders at school; Ch. 20 Learning from failure
11	Ch. 21 Power given up; Ch. 23 Your decisions
12	Ch. 22 Your writing; Ch. 24 Your leadership

The extended edition

Week	Chapter	
1	P1 Before the Greeks: farming, writing and the first laws	core
2	P2 The first Greeks: palaces, collapse and memory	core
3	Ch. 1 The self: honor	core
4	Ch. 2 The household: mind and home	core
5	Ch. 3 The city at war: the citizen-soldier	core
6	Ch. 4 The city's law: conscience and the court	extended only
7	Ch. 5 The city questioned: Socrates	core
8	Ch. 6 The ideal city: proof, and how constitutions decay	core
9	Ch. 7 The citizen's judgment: practical wisdom	core
10	Ch. 8 The whole city: the balanced constitution	core
11	Ch. 9 The family and the nation: duty	extended only
12	Ch. 10 The republic: law and the mixed constitution	core

Week	Chapter	
13	Ch. 11 The forum: eloquence in public service	core
14	Ch. 12 The statesman: character in public life	core
15	Ch. 13 The ruler under empire: self-command	core
16	Ch. 14 The empire: building at scale, and the fall	extended only
17	Ch. 15 Christendom: law above kings	core
18	Ch. 16 The Italian cities: the ancients reborn	extended only
19	Ch. 17 The cosmos: the laws of nature	extended only
20	Ch. 18 The nation-state: rights, consent and balanced power	core
21	Ch. 19 The Founders at school: the Declaration as an argument	core
22	Ch. 20 Learning from failure: designing the Constitution	core
23	Ch. 21 Power given up: Washington	core
24	Ch. 22 Your writing: persuasion	core
25	Ch. 23 Your decisions: judging the hard case	core
26	Ch. 24 Your leadership: self-command, and the capstone	core

Adapting the exercises

Every chapter ends with one of the progymnasmata, the graded writing drills of the classical schools: the fable, the narrative, the chreia, the maxim, the refutation and the rest. Each drill has fixed steps, and the student works through them in order. Most also ask the reader to apply the drill to "your own work". For a student, translate that into the parts of life where they have real responsibility:

- schoolwork, a group project or a difficult class;
- a sports team, an orchestra, a debate club or a church youth group;
- a part-time job, volunteering, or a younger sibling they look after;
- a decision they face: a course of study, a college, a disagreement with a friend.

The last three chapters (22–24) ask for a memo, a written decision and a short talk. A student can write the memo to a club or a coach, decide a real question in their own life, and give the talk to the family at dinner.

Checking the writing

You do not need training in rhetoric to check a drill. The steps are printed in each chapter, so the first question is simply whether each step is there and in order. Then ask:

Question	What to look for
Is every step there, in order?	The drill's steps are the skeleton. A missing step is the most common fault.
Does each step do its job?	A "cause" gives a real reason, not a restatement. An "example from another time" is a true example, correctly told.
Is the source right?	Names, dates and quotations match the chapter. Quotations are copied exactly, not from memory.
Is it the right length?	Each drill gives a length, often about 300 words. Shorter usually means a step was skipped.
Does it read well aloud?	Have the student read it to you. Sentences they stumble over are the ones to rewrite.

A simple scale works: **revise** (steps missing or wrong), **sound** (every step present and doing its job), **strong** (sound, and also clear, accurate and worth reading). Ask for one revision of anything marked "revise". Keep the drafts: by the end of the course the change from the first chreia to the last memo is the best evidence of progress you will have.

Talking it over

These five questions work for any chapter:

1. What did this age add to the man the book is building?
2. Where did it fall short, and what did the next age have to fix?
3. Which passage would you copy into your commonplace book, and why?
4. Where have you seen this in real life, at school, at home or in the news?
5. What would you do differently, now that you have read it?

Each chapter also names a word of the chapter in Greek or Latin and four Latin phrases. Use them during the week; a student who hears *bona fide* or *prima facie* at dinner remembers it.

The commonplace book

Each chapter suggests an entry for the commonplace book: a passage copied by hand and two sentences on what it means. Give your student a good notebook at the start. Look through it once a month: the entries should be copied exactly, dated, and followed by the student's own words. It is the one part of the course they keep for life.

Credit and transcripts

The extended edition is about 90 hours of work across 26 weeks; the core course is roughly half that. Many homeschool families count about 120 hours of work as one high-school credit, so the extended edition, with discussion and revised writing, can support a half credit or more. How you assign credit is your decision, and the rules vary by state and by umbrella school, so check what yours require.

The course crosses subjects. Depending on your plan, record it as history, literature, English composition or humanities, or split it across two.

> **A course description you may adapt:**
>
> *Classical Foundations: From the First Cities to the American Founding*. A study of the Western tradition through primary sources in translation, from the *Epic of Gilgamesh* and Homer through Herodotus, Thucydides, Sophocles, Plato, Aristotle, Virgil, Livy, Cicero, Plutarch, Seneca and Marcus Aurelius, to Aquinas and Magna Carta, Machiavelli, Copernicus, Galileo and Newton, Locke and Montesquieu, and the writings of Jefferson, Madison and Washington. The student completed the progymnasmata, the graded writing exercises of the classical schools, wrote a weekly commonplace-book entry, learned Latin terms used in law, medicine and business, and finished with a written argument, a written decision and a short public talk. Text: *Sophandros* (sophandros.com).

For a portfolio, keep the drills (first drafts and revisions), the commonplace book, and a list of the readings completed.

Questions

Write to education@sophandros.com. Questions from parents help us make the course better for the next family.